

COAT, WAISTCOAT, AND BREECHES

STREAMLINED COURT SUIT

This man's court outfit from 1780, embellished ornately with a floral theme, is a typical example of a rococo, French-style suit known as the *habit à la Française*. Such suits consisted of a coat (*habit*), waistcoat, and knee breeches, worn with a white shirt, a jabot frill, ruffled cuffs, and silk stockings. The striking colours, lavish fabrics, and extravagant embroidery continued a trend for bright colours and decoration from the 1600s. Characteristic of the pre-French Revolution period, outfits such as these were typically worn by the 18th-century upper-class man. Suit cloth often came already embroidered – known as *à la disposition* – prior to being made up. The slim, fitted cut of this suit is typical of the later 1700s, with its streamlined, unpadded coat and shorter, sleeveless waistcoat. As the Revolution (1789–99) approached, stripes became popular – this cut-velvet coat is striped with pink.



△ WAISTCOAT

With its very shallow, cutaway skirt fronts, this distinctive shape is typical of the era. The front section is made of ivory satin richly embroidered with coloured silks. The pale colour shows off the embroidery and contrasts with the dark coat.

Narrow-wristed, slim sleeves contribute to the elegant shape

Decorative shirt-cuff ruffles

Tiny flower sprigs embroidered across the ivory silk

Three-pointed, decorated pocket flaps

Embroidery design on one side mirrors that on the other

Narrow, cutaway sides to reveal decorated waistcoat

Breeches dark (once black) velvet patterned with tiny, pink diamonds

Breeches tighter fitting, like coat and waistcoat

Jabot frill at the neck

